

Afternoon Discoveries

Friday, September 18, 2026



AMONG THE LETTERS

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Today's focus: Creative Nonfiction,

Memoirs, Essays, & Narrative Journalism

A thread runs through several of today's strongest pieces through concrete details doing work that explanation cannot.

All current discoveries below were checked against their publication, publisher, or author source on September 18, 2026.

Featured Discovery

"The Best Day Ever" - Tess Kelly

A new micro essay in *Brevity* begins with the relationship between an ESL teacher and a young Afghan refugee and turns on the complicated ways children remember violence, safety, and happiness.

What makes it worth reading as craft is its restraint. Kelly does not need a large canvas to create the turn. Memory is concentrated into a child's idea of what constitutes the "best" day, giving the final emotional movement more force than a lengthy explanation would.

Read "The Best Day Ever" at [Brevity](#)

Friday Discoveries

"I Was at Ground Zero" - The Thing I Remember Most Is a Plate of

Rigatoni” - Pat DePaul

Published by *Narratively* on September 11, this memoir follows DePaul’s experience as a young volunteer firefighter after the September 11 attacks.

The title gives away the piece’s most useful craft lesson: enormous events are often remembered through strangely ordinary things. Here, a plate of food becomes an anchor for exhaustion, guilt, care, and memory.

[Read the essay at Narratively](#)

“Going Up and Going In” - Brian Laidlaw

This September 1 Longreads excerpt comes from Laidlaw’s new book *Erratica: On Climbing, Language, and Touching Stone*, published by Milkweed Editions this month. It moves through solo climbing, risk, and the inner arguments people construct around dangerous choices.

For nonfiction writers, the attraction is not simply the climbing subject. Physical movement becomes a way into philosophical inquiry without losing the pressure of an actual scene.

[Read “Going Up and Going In” at Longreads](#)

***Triangularity: Essays on Poetry, Science, and Spirit* - Alice Major**

University of Alberta Press released the paperback edition of Alice Major's collection in August, with its digital editions following on September 17. The book combines personal essays and poems while exploring the relationships among science, poetry, belief, and creative practice.

Major has long worked at the meeting point between scientific ideas and literary language. For readers interested in essay forms that can hold intellectual argument without becoming conventional criticism, this is a timely Canadian release.

[View *Triangularity* at University of Alberta Press](#)

**“Writing Through Loss: On Crafting
Nonfiction That Tackles America’s Opioid
Crisis”
- Nadia Bowers and Stephanie Wittels
Wachs**

Published September 17 at *Literary Hub*, this conversation brings together two writers whose nonfiction grew out of losing siblings to overdose.

The discussion is useful precisely because it stays close to the problem of craft: how private grief changes when it becomes a book, how a writer handles responsibility to other people in the story, and what happens when personal loss intersects with a much larger social crisis.

[Read the conversation at Literary Hub](#)

If you find interest in strolling Among the Letters some more, we would greatly appreciate your support.

Thank you for reading!

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More Creative Nonfiction, Memoir & Essays

Special Recommendations can be found near the bottom of the article.

“We Walk a Figure Eight” - Suzanne Farrell Smith

Another new piece from *Brevity*, built around the literal route of a school pickup walk. The essay uses that repeated physical pattern to hold parenting, memory, and attention together.

It is a good example of finding structure in something the narrator is already doing rather than imposing a visible framework after the fact.

Read “We Walk a Figure Eight” at [Brevity](#)

“Am I dead inside?” - Anastasia Nikolis

Nikolis’s new *Brevity* essay works in a more experimental mode, moving through art, body, place, and a decision about motherhood.

Its interest is partly formal. The piece gives the reader fragments and spatial relationships rather than smoothing everything into a conventional narrative line.

[Read "Am I dead inside?" at Brevity](#)

"List of Lasts" - Marcia Aldrich

A new abecedarian, list-shaped essay from *Brevity* that builds itself from different kinds of "lasts."

The form could easily become a gimmick, but the accumulating entries instead create pressure around memory, aging, and mortality. Writers experimenting with list essays may find the structural economy especially useful.

[Read "List of Lasts" at Brevity](#)

"The 'Great' Opportunity That Left Me Penniless in NYC" - Jennifer Silva Redmond

Published by *Narratively* on September 4, Redmond recounts moving to New York for what looked like an extraordinary nannying opportunity, only to have the arrangement unravel when her employers' checks began bouncing.

The piece works as memoir because the reversal is not merely financial. It tracks the psychological distance between the life Redmond thought she was entering and the one she suddenly had to survive.

[Read the story at Narratively](#)

“Eating Alone” - Gabe Bullard

This September 15 Longreads excerpt from Bullard’s *Against Convenience* examines food delivery, ghost kitchens, and what convenience can alter about the social experience of eating.

It sits nicely between essay and narrative journalism. An everyday habit becomes the entry point into a larger investigation without the human scale disappearing beneath the reporting.

[Read “Eating Alone” at Longreads](#)

***The Wind Carries Me / Le Vent me porte* - Andrew Fuchs**

Second Story Press released this bilingual memoir on September 1. Fuchs recounts surviving the Holocaust as a child in Hungary, including separation from his parents, before following the life he rebuilt after the war and his eventual immigration to Canada.

For memoir readers, it is also a reminder that testimony is shaped not only by what can be remembered, but by the distance between the child who experienced an event and the adult who eventually narrates it.

[View *The Wind Carries Me / Le Vent me porte* at Second Story Press](#)

The Essential Janet Hardy **- Janet W. Hardy**

Released September 8 by Unbound Edition Press, this collection gathers work spanning roughly three decades. The essays move through identity, desire, motherhood, relationships, and chosen family.

A collection assembled across that much time offers something a newly written memoir cannot: the chance to see how the writer's subjects and perspective change across different periods of a life.

[View *The Essential Janet Hardy* at Unbound Edition Press](#)

Our Secrets Are the Same **- Jim Kerr and Charlie Burchill** **with Graeme Thomson**

Released in North America by ECW Press on September 8, this joint memoir follows the Simple Minds founders through decades of friendship, music, marriages, divorce, fatherhood, fame, and the changing dynamics inside the band.

The dual perspective is the interesting formal element here. Memoir usually grants one consciousness control of the past. A shared life narrated by two participants gives memory someone to argue with.

[View *Our Secrets Are the Same* at ECW Press](#)

“A Dispatch from the Tour(ish)” - Elizabeth Jannuzzi

Jannuzzi’s September 14 newsletter dispatch arrives alongside the audiobook release of her recovery memoir *Sober Mom*.

One small detail makes it especially useful for writers: she describes the experience of reading the entire manuscript aloud before final submission. It is a simple revision technique, but one capable of exposing rhythm, repetition, and awkwardness that silent rereading misses.

[Read “A Dispatch from the Tour\(ish\)” on Substack](#)

***Designing in the Dark: A Memoir of Vision, Resilience, and Redefining Canadian Design* - George Sully**

Forthcoming from ECW Press on October 6, Sully’s memoir follows his path through Canadian fashion and design, entrepreneurship, identity, and the obstacles surrounding that career.

It looks particularly relevant for readers interested in creative-industry memoirs, where the work itself becomes part of the life story rather than merely its setting.

[View *Designing in the Dark* at ECW Press](#)

Special Recommendations

These are intentionally not presented as new releases. They are older pieces that fit today's nonfiction and narrative-journalism focus well enough to merit another look.

“The Fourth State of Matter” - Jo Ann Beard

Originally published in *The New Yorker* in 1996, Beard's essay braids domestic upheaval, her work in a university physics department, and the 1991 University of Iowa shooting.

Its reputation is deserved, but the practical reason to revisit it is structure. Beard lets apparently separate strands gather meaning beside one another until the connections become unavoidable, without stopping to announce what each strand is supposed to symbolize.

[Read “The Fourth State of Matter” at The New Yorker](#)

“The Really Big One” - Kathryn Schulz

Schulz's 2015 *New Yorker* feature on the Cascadia subduction zone and earthquake risk remains a strong model of narrative science journalism.

The subject demands large amounts of geological explanation, but the story keeps translating scale into scenes, people, and consequences a reader can grasp. That balance between technical accuracy and narrative momentum is worth studying even when the reporting subject is completely different.

[Read “The Really Big One” at The New Yorker](#)

“And There’s Your Mother, Calling Out to You: In Pursuit of Memory” - Beth Kephart

This 2013 craft essay from *Brevity* examines the problem every memoir writer eventually encounters: memory does not arrive on command.

Kephart considers sensory and material routes back into the past - photographs, music, objects, weather, landscapes, and other fragments that can recover more than an instruction to simply “remember.”

Read Beth Kephart’s craft essay at [Brevity](#)

Today’s pieces make a useful argument for specificity without ever having to state one. Difficult subjects do not necessarily require bigger language, often they require a smaller and more exact thing for the reader to hold onto.

Thank you for reading and subscribing. Your support makes it possible to publish articles like these for everyone.

I hope something here stays with you, sends you toward a writer you had not encountered before, or gives you an idea worth carrying into your own work.

Take care!